White Supremacy Culture

Summary

From Dismantling Racism: A Workbook for Social Change Groups, by Kenneth Jones and Tema Okun, ChangeWork, 2001

Characteristic	Antidotes
Perfectionism • focus on what is wrong • "mistakes" seen as personal, shameful • little reflection when things go wrong, hard to learn from "mistakes"	• develop culture of appreciation • develop learning organization, "mistakes" seen as opportunities • when giving feedback, always speak to the things that went well first
Sense of Urgency • there is no "time" to be inclusive, be thoughtful, consider the long term consequences • default is to the current (white) norm	• be realistic about how long things take • understand that there are no shortcuts to building a diverse community • adhere to agreed-upon decision-making processes; no "shortcuts"
Defensiveness • criticism of those in power seen as threatening, rude or inappropriate (due to either/or thinking) • new/different ideas seen as threatening	• name defensiveness as an issue and explore how it impedes the mission • understand the link between defensiveness and fear; think of building community as • as an antidote to fear •
Quantity over Quality • focus on content rather than process • emphasis on what can be easily and "objectively" measured • discomfort with emotions and tension • results in decisions that don't stick	• adhere to organizational values that value inclusion and process • develop protocols for knowing when to move off content and into process, and build skills in having difficult conversations

Characteristic	Antidotes
Worship of the Written Word • if it's not written down, it doesn't exist • those with strong documentation and writing skills are more highly valued, whether this is related to the organizational mission or not • there is one right way to do things • There is a tendency to conflate one's writing skills with intelligence.	• acknowledge that there are many ways of reaching the same goal • accepting and implementing decisions made in different ways • understand that there are many skillful ways of being in the world and it is desirable for all to flourish
Paternalism • decision-making is clear to those with power and unclear to those without it • those with power think they are capable of making decisions for and in the interests of those without power • those without power understand they do not have it and understand who does	• develop clear and transparent decision-making processes • clearly define roles and responsibilities • emphasize transparency and discussion • Authentically invite feedback
Either/Or Thinking • unable to see "both/and" • hard to learn from experience or accommodate diverse views • fosters conflict, urgency, oversimplification of complex issues	• notice when either/or thinking arises and note this out loud as a group • when there is pressure to make a decision "right away," take time to lower the emotional temperature and consider alternatives
Power Hoarding • little value around sharing power • those with power believe that they have the whole organization's interests at heart and see those advocating change as ill-informed or... • those in power don't see themselves as hoarding power	• actively share power, e.g., by rotating leadership positions • clearly define and abide by organizational roles and responsibilities • emphasize leaders' responsibility to develop others' leadership skills • stay focused on the mission
Fear of Open Conflict • emphasis on being "polite" • those who bring up difficult issues are seen as "rude," blamed for "causing problems"	• build distress tolerance and conflict management skills • use discomfort as a signal for investigation
Individualism • emphasize (supposed) individual achievement, competition over cooperation • fosters isolation • leads to focus on individual vs collective/ organizational goals	• support teamwork and develop related skills • emphasize collective goals • actively give credit to everyone contributing to a process/activity/goal
Progress is Bigger/More • assume that increasing in size is necessarily a good thing	• carefully evaluate plans and proposals for their impact on the mission/community

Characteristic	Antidotes
Objectivity • belief that there is such a thing as “objective” • devalues emotion (and people expressing emotion), hypervalues “logic” (and people arguing logically)	• accept that there are many ways to experience a given situation • assume that everyone has a valid point and it is your job to understand it fully
Right to Comfort • those with power have a right to be comfortable • scapegoating those who “cause” discomfort	• hold the systemic view that allows you to not take things personally • accept that change and inclusion brings discomfort